

Digital Passion | MP3 Player Test

from dance tracks. Its cousin, the YP F1, balanced the bass and treble a lot better.

To state the obvious about the iPod nano, it's good to have one if you can afford it. As for the best of the rest, while they may not have the flaunt value the iPod has, they offer excellent sound quality and come with the usual works—FM, recording capability, and so on. The Transcend T.sonic 610, the D1, Z5 and F1 from Samsung, YMP 920, Sony NW E307, and the SAFA Q100 find a place in the Best of the Rest list.

We expected more from the Sony Network Walkman (NW) series. The NW E105, especially, could have done better in the bass department. The 1 GB E307 comes for Rs 10,490, while the T.Sonic 610, which sounds just as good, if not better, costs just a little over half that price—Rs 5,500 for the same memory. Sony seems to have banked on their image a little too much!

All the players in the Creative MuVo family are similar, even on the battery life front. The design and look of the XFREE XFL series seems a straight lift from the MuVos—to the extent where we wondered if Creative and the XFREE were the same! The XFREE players, however, are a notch below the MuVo players when it comes to sound clarity.

In most players, the bottleneck for good sound quality

lies with the bundled earphones. This was plainly evident with the XFREE players—merely changing the earphones improved the sound quality by an appreciable amount. The Bravish M 339 was another player that can produce good sound, but the earphones played spoilsport. While not every set of earphones is compatible with every player, sometimes using one from a higher model can actually bridge the gap between mere sound and blissful music!

A Look At Looks

Beauty is skin deep. Well, maybe. But we *are* interested in the skin here!

Just how differently can you design a box? Some have curved edges while some are protruding, some have a graceful single colour while other have jazzy combinations; stickers, too, are generously used to add character to the products.

Samsung's YP F1, on first sight, resembles a small flip-open phone, but looks good nevertheless. Love-it-or-hate-it is what Sony E307's bean shape is all about. Transcend's T.sonic 610 is sleek, light and elegant in its own right, though not bold or colourful in design.

The two mobiBLU models we received left

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SAFA SF-Q100

How We Tested

We aimed to make our test process as realistic as possible, so real-world tests dominated our test pattern.

All the hard drive-based MP3 players were interfaced to a PC running on an AMD Athlon XP 2400+ for the battery charging and data transfer tests. The system was built around the NVIDIA

nForce 2 chipset with the latest nForce drivers, 512 MB of Hynix DDR 333 MHz SDRAM, a Seagate Barracuda 80 GB hard disk, on-board sound, and a GeForce 5200FX AGP Card. All the Flash-based players were tested on an Intel Pentium 4 HT 3.2 GHZ with

1 GB of DDR533 RAM and a MAXTOR 120 GB SATA I hard drive. Both the machines ran Windows XP with Service Pack 2 to enable full support for USB 2.0 from the OS side.

Both our test categories went through the same test process, except that we used different machines for the data transfer tests. The test process is broadly classified into five main sections: Features, Accessories, Ergonomics and Ease of Use, Performance, and Price Index.

Under Features, we noted supported audio formats, FM, direct Line-in encoding, display type, number of colours in the display, etc. Some players had extra features such as video and photo support, which were given extra points.

Scores were also given to the available accessories. These scores, however, do not affect our overall score in a big way, as the weight given to this section is the lowest amongst the five. This section mainly features as information on the package contents.

Factors such as button placement and portability matter a lot. Do spend time looking at these before buying. We took both

the physical (button) interface as well as the software interface of the player into account here.

Features and Performance were given equal consideration, because as a buyer, one would like to buy a good-quality player that is feature-rich at the same time. We carried out a thorough test to check the players' audio output quality. We chose bass-centric tracks (such as *Smack my b**ch up* by Prodigy) and a few tracks that were reliant on treble (such as music by Joe Satriani and Steve Vai). Trance music has a blend of bass, treble and electronics such as effects of synthesizers and disc scratch, making for a complete sound package. Vocal tracks such as *Maan Ki Lagan* from *Paap* and *Punjab* by *Karunesh* helped us judge overall playback quality for more mellow tracks. It also helped in judging whether bass and treble were overshadowing each other, and if the result subdued the vocals.

Usable storage capacity was also noted. We've deliberately not awarded points for capacity in the Features segment—the effect of capacity will automatically reflect in the Price Index, which is the ratio of the cost of a player to its actual capacity. This gives us an idea of the amount a buyer will have to pay per MB (Flash-based) or GB (HDD-based). What you pay for the *features* comes under the Features department.

Files amounting to 100 MB (Flash-based) and 1 GB (HDD-based) were used to determine data transfer rate. A battery drain test was conducted by keeping a player at 65 per cent volume and looping tracks non-stop, until playback stopped. The start time and end time were noted to give the battery life of the player. Out-of-the-pack Duracell alkaline AA and AAA batteries were used for the players that needed them. Both these tests fall under the Performance segment.